

RIVERS AND LAKES

Every continent—even Antarctica, where most water is locked up in ice—has rivers and freshwater lakes. Rivers are fed by groundwater springs, lakes, glaciers, and surface runoff. Measured by the amount of water flowing through its channels, the Amazon–Orinoco basin in South America

is the largest, while the Nile, in Africa, closely followed by the Amazon, is the longest. The largest lake by volume is Lake Baikal in Russia, which formed as a result of Earth's crust being pulled apart. Lakes also form in basins with no outlet, in volcanic craters, and behind natural and artificial dams.

North America

Great Bear Lake

Location Northwest Territories, western Canada

The eighth largest lake in the world by surface area, the Great Bear Lake is also deep, plunging to 1,355 ft (413 m). It drains to the west, via the Great Bear River, to the mighty Mackenzie River. Its waters are cold and, being both far from oceanic influences and close to the Arctic Circle, it is frozen from November to July. It is the largest inland body of water to exist at such a high latitude. During the last glaciation, about 10,000 years ago, it was part of the even larger Lake McConnell, another glacial lake.

Spotted Lake

Location British Columbia, western Canada

Also known as Lake Okanagan, this salty alkaline basin contains some of the most mineral-rich waters on Earth—and the most colorful—with high concentrations of magnesium sulfate, calcium, and sodium sulfate, as well as smaller amounts of silver and titanium. Each summer, as the lake's waters evaporate, about 300 small, shallow pools are all that remain, each colored



▲ COLORFUL MINERAL DEPOSITS ON SPOTTED LAKE

according to the minerals concentrated within—a mix of blue, green, yellow, and orange. The lake is a traditional healing

site for the First Nations of Okanagan, who use its mud and water to treat aches, pains, and other medical problems.

The Columbia River

Location From British Columbia to Oregon, western North America

This river has the largest volume of any river flowing into the Pacific Ocean from the Americas. It rises in the Rocky Mountains of British Columbia and flows 1,200 miles (2,000 km) through a drainage basin the size of France before entering the Pacific between Oregon and Washington. The river's steep

